

The Firefly Lanterns

The blossom mountains of Yamato rise in soft green folds above terraced rice fields and little villages strung with paper lanterns, where cherry trees drop their petals on the wind and red torii gates mark the quiet shrines. Mist drifts among the bamboo, the moon lays a silver path on the river, and the hills are full of gentle spirits: a riddling fox, shy fireflies who light the lanterns, a jolly trickster tanuki, stone guardian dogs, and a great old river dragon who brings the rains. Here a hero is not the strongest or the loudest, but the one who is patient, thinks things through, and is kind to every living thing. The grandest deeds are done with imagination and courage and a gentle heart, and even a fearsome guardian, met with a calm and friendly word, often turns out kinder than it looks.

The answers are here. This part is for the grown-up, not for the child.

Show the matching picture in the Atlas as you reach each place.



Read aloud, slowly and warmly. Stop often to let the children answer. There are no wrong answers here, only brave new ideas to try.

Before you begin

Tonight is the summer Lantern Festival in the Lantern Village. Every year the paper lanterns glow, and the whole village dances under their warm light. But something is wrong. The lanterns will not light. They hang grey and dark in the evening air.

The reason is a quiet one. Inside each lantern lives a shy little Firefly Spirit, and tonight every one of them has flown off to hide. They are deep in the Whispering Bamboo Grove, in the dark, too timid to come out.

Granny Yuki the Tale-Keeper calls you to her side. "You two have heads full of ideas and kind hearts," she says. "Will you go to the grove and gently coax the firefly spirits back, so our festival can glow?"

She gives you three gifts: a paper lantern, a ball of red thread, and a soft, sweet rice cake. Then she smiles. "Up in the hills we do not win by being loud or strong. We win by being brave, kind, and full of ideas."



What is your hero name? Will you carry Imagination, Courage, or Kindness?

Stop 1 The Dark Bamboo

You climb the path to the Whispering Bamboo Grove. The tall stalks click and whisper in the wind. It is dark in here, and very still. Somewhere close, tiny lights blink on and off, then hide again. The firefly spirits are here, but they are shy.

A russet fox steps softly from the green shadows. It is Kon the Fox, with bright, lively eyes and a little leaf on his head. He gives you a friendly wink.



The spirits are timid. What kind thing could you do? Could you move gently and speak softly? You have a sweet rice cake to share. Could you sit very still and let them come to you?

When you are calm and kind, one little light drifts near. Then another. Soon a cloud of tiny golden fireflies floats around you, no longer afraid. "Well done," whispers Kon. "They trust you now."

Stop 2 The Lantern Path

The fireflies will follow you home, but only if they feel safe. A long path of empty paper lanterns leads down the hill to the village. If you light them in the right order, a gentle path of light will guide the shy spirits all the way.

But which lantern first? They come in many sizes, and your ball of red thread runs from one to the next, tying them in a line.



How will you light them so the spirits feel safe? Could you go from the smallest lantern to the biggest? Could you simply follow the red thread from lantern to lantern? Could you ask Kon the Fox for a hint?

When you find the gentle order and light them one by one, a soft road of golden light opens up. The little fireflies bob along it happily, following you down the hill.

Stop 3 The Great Lantern

At the top of the festival square stands the Great Lantern, the biggest of them all. To light it, the shyest little firefly of all must fly up inside. But this one is the most timid, and it hangs back, trembling, afraid of the great dark lantern.

This is not a fight. The little firefly just needs to feel brave.



What could you say to help it? Could you speak in a soft, calm voice? Could you tell it that you believe in it, and that you will be right here? Could you show it how brave it already is?

When you cheer it on with calm and kindness, the little firefly takes a deep breath and flies up. The Great Lantern fills with warm light, the brightest of all.

The Festival Glows

One by one, every lantern in the village glows golden. The dark is gone. The firefly spirits swirl and dance in the warm air, looping in happy circles, no longer shy at all.

The whole village cheers and laughs and begins to dance. Drums beat softly. The lanterns sway like a sky full of small warm moons.

When morning comes, warm Amaterasu the Sun-Kami lifts over the hills and smiles down at you. You did it together. You were brave, you were kind, and most of all, you were full of ideas. Well done, heroes.

The Firefly Lanterns: Rules for the Grown-Up

New to this? Read the Guide for the Grown-Up first. It explains the whole idea in two pages and you will never need it again.

You are the Game Master, which here means a few small jobs at once: storyteller, gentle referee, the children's biggest fan, and a fellow adventurer who plays along. This is a cooperative game for two or more who play together, a grown-up and one or more children, all on the same side. Nobody competes, and nobody loses. This is a gentle tale, soft and warm from start to finish, and no one is ever frightened or hurt.

Setting up

- Print the map. Each player puts a small figure on the Start, the Lantern Village.
- This world has no magic. Instead each hero leans on one of three qualities: **Imagination** (dreaming up ideas), **Courage** (a steady heart), or **Kindness** (caring for others). On the hero sheet, where it says magic, let each child write the quality they like best. Two different qualities work best together.
- Give each player five energy stars (five small tokens or bricks). They are spent and refilled during play.
- Set out three props if you can: a paper cup or anything round for the paper lantern, a ball of red string or wool for the red thread, and any small token for the rice cake. Anything can be anything.
- Keep your dice and the dice-band table from the back of the kit beside you.

Difficulty bands, not dice

Challenges never call for a particular die. Each one has a band: **Easy**, **Normal**, or **Hard**. When the players try something, look up the band on the kit's dice-band table, which tells you the number to meet or beat with whatever dice your family owns. Every challenge can be played with a single ordinary die.

The golden rule: here nobody loses

A failed roll is never a defeat. It is a detour to a different route. When a roll does not meet the band, the players always have a way through:

- **Spend an energy star** to gather themselves and try the idea again, or
- **Join two qualities** once per stop to pass with no roll at all (Imagination and Kindness together, say, or Courage and Imagination).

Energy stars come back when the players move on to the next stop, and when they help each other. Nobody can ever run dry for long, and nobody is ever stuck.

Helping each other: the Helping Hand

At any moment one player may help another instead of acting alone. When they do, make the help roll: on a success the challenge is passed for the pair, even if the first roll missed. Helping is generous, so reward it; it also tops up an energy star. On a night like this, no hero shines alone.

The Twist of Fate

At each stop, once, the players may roll for a twist and you read out the matching line. Use whichever die the dice-band table gives you for this; with a single ordinary die, read the line that matches the number rolled.

Roll	Twist of Fate
1	Kon the Fox slips from the bamboo and gives you one free hint.
2	You find your calm again, and take back one energy star.
3	A soft breeze drifts down the hill, and the next challenge is Easy.
4	The Guardian Lion-Dogs nod kindly from the gate. All is well.
5	A lucky cherry petal lands on your shoulder: keep one roll to use again later.
6	The soft ring of a temple bell, and for a moment everyone feels calm and brave.

How it ends

The shyest little firefly at the Great Lantern is the last "challenge", but it is no foe. It is simply a small spirit that feels too timid to shine. The tale is won not by pushing it but by encouraging it with a calm and kindly word, and the festival blazes into light. Let the kindness land; it is the whole point. See the puzzles page for the three challenges and their solutions.

The Firefly Lanterns: Puzzles and Solutions

For your eyes, not the children's. Each stop lists its band, what the players need to work out, the intended solution, and a gentle fallback so a stuck child always moves forward. More than one good idea should work; reward imagination and kindness over the "right" answer.

Stop 1: The Dark Bamboo (Easy)

The challenge. The Firefly Spirits are hiding in the dark of the Whispering Bamboo Grove, blinking on and off and darting away. They are gentle but very shy, and they cannot be caught or chased.

Intended solution. This is a Kindness and Observation moment. The caring move is to slow right down: move gently, keep voices soft, sit still, and offer the sweet **rice cake** so the spirits feel safe enough to come close on their own. Patience and a quiet, friendly manner are what win them over, not speed.

Fallback. If the children grow restless or try to grab the lights, have **Kon the Fox** murmur, "They come to calm hearts, not quick hands," and show them how to sit still. The moment they settle and wait kindly, a firefly drifts down to them, and the rest follow. A gentle try always works.

Stop 2: The Lantern Path (Normal)

The challenge. A long row of empty paper lanterns leads down the hill to the village. The players must light them in an order gentle enough that the shy spirits will feel safe to follow.

Intended solution. This is an Imagination, Logic and Observation moment. The thoughtful move is to find a calm, clear pattern: lighting from the **smallest lantern to the biggest** so the path grows gently, or simply following the **red thread** that ties the lanterns in their proper line from one to the next. Any thought-through order that the children can explain works just as well.

Fallback. If they are unsure where to start, let the **red thread** show the way (follow it bead by bead), or have **Kon the Fox** point his nose down the line with a hint. They may also spend an energy star to "remember" the pattern. Getting there with help still counts as a full success and tops up an energy star.

Stop 3: The Great Lantern (Normal)

The challenge. The Great Lantern at the top of the square must be lit by the shyest little firefly of all, but this one is too timid and hangs back, trembling. The players may want to push or hurry it. They should not.

Intended solution. This is a Kindness and Courage moment. The little firefly only needs encouragement. Any genuine, calming kindness works: speaking in a soft and steady voice, saying "I believe in you" and "I will be right here", or reminding it how brave it has already been tonight. When the children cheer it on gently, it gathers its courage, flies up, and the Great Lantern blooms with the warmest light of all.

Fallback. If the children freeze, or try to nudge the firefly up by force, have it shrink back and whisper, "Will you stay with me?" A single kind, calm word is enough. The moment the players offer any warm encouragement at all, the little spirit finds its courage and the great lantern lights.

The ending

There is no battle and no loser. When the Great Lantern lights, every lantern in the village glows gold, the firefly spirits dance free in the warm night, and the whole village cheers and

begins the festival. By morning, warm **Amaterasu the Sun-Kami** rises and smiles down on the valley. The heroes have won the only way anyone wins here, by being brave, kind, and full of ideas.

Wander and Tales

Tale Book

<https://github.com/agigante80/wander-and-tales>

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Here nobody loses. If a try does not work, find another way.